



Practicing sustainable eating: zooming in a civic food network

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Abstract

In the last 2 decades, the literature has documented the upsurge of community-driven processes of consumer-producer cooperation, which are alternative to the dominant food system. These organizational arrangements have been conceptualized differently, witnessing the growing importance of local communities in generating place-based solutions to the demand for organic, local, and sustainable food. Relying on a practice theory approach, this article delves into two key inquiries: first, what motivates individuals to become part of Civic Food Networks (CFNs) and how does this influence the variety of food entering their households? And second, how does participation in a CFN impact people's daily food practices, with a particular focus on diet diversification? We employ the term “civic food networks (CFN)” to underscore the significance of grassroots initiatives in the broader context of local food policies. This term also highlights the connections to other movements known for their potential for transformation, such as the solidarity economy, transition towns, and de-growth movements. Our analysis draws on a comprehensive qualitative approach, which includes participant observation, in-depth interviews, and a focus group involving members of the CSA *Naturalmente in Trentino*, situated in the North-Eastern part of Italy. The findings reveal that altering dietary habits poses various challenges both at the individual and institutional levels. This process involves the stabilization of ingrained habits, adjustments to daily routines, and the reinforcement of shared norms. Furthermore, it underscores the critical role of food policies in promoting sustainable eating practices.

Keywords Social practices · Everyday life · Alternative food networks · Civic food networks · Food policies

Introduction

Today's food system is marked by discernible challenges and, at times, paradoxes stemming from disparities in food distribution. On the one hand, we assist to a striking percentage of food waste (one third of the world food production yearly), a large quote of the agricultural production dedicated to biofuel and animal feed, and raising obesity rates, while on the other hand, vast sectors of the world population are increasingly striving to access food, in a worsening scenario characterized by the impact of climate change. Moreover, unhealthy diets cause 11 million deaths every year, while 420,000 people are dying from consuming unsafe food. Three billion people are currently unable to afford a healthy diet, making malnutrition an important driver of social inequalities (WHO, 2021). Against this background,

the need for a food system change becomes apparent, even though proposed answers greatly differ among each other.

On the one hand, an often-proposed solution is the so-called technological fix, that is to say an attempt to solve the issue that is based on technology or engineering. Some examples, in this sense, are cultured meat, precision agriculture, drones and artificial intelligence. The technological fix has raised a lot of criticism and, following Fuchs et al. (2021), it is possible to highlight three main flaws: first, technological innovation is rarely employed in favor of low-income people, who suffer the most in terms of access to healthy food; second, these innovations are usually thought as a way of fixing a problem that is mainly addressed when it has already produced its negative impacts, avoiding to act preventively; third, they stress the problem of the so-called “rebound effect”, which implies that, in the neoliberal context, the emphasis given to the idea of efficiency leads to a more intense use of resources. This in turn implies more consumption, not being a real solution to issues of food commodification, scarcity due to unequal distribution and food waste.

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On the other hand, governance is reputed by many as a more effective instrument towards possible transitions to sustainability, especially when policies are place-based and co-created such as in the framework of Food Policy Councils (Giambartolomei et al. 2021; Michel-Villarreal et al., 2019; Matacena 2016). In this context, a variety of initiatives, including box schemes, community-supported agriculture, farmers' markets, consumer and producer cooperatives, community gardening projects, and solidarity purchasing groups, have been implemented with varying effects in different settings, both in the Global North and South.

By shortening the supply chain, reinforcing mutual trust between producers and consumers, promoting small, often organic, agricultural enterprises that produce quality food at reasonable prices, these arrangements, that have been defined in several ways (such as alternative food networks, short food-supply chains, civic food networks, local food networks), have been key to the analysis of community-based solutions to the aforementioned issues.

Expanding upon the foundation laid by previous research that has examined the internal organizational functioning of these networks (as demonstrated by Brunori et al. 2012; Pole and Gray 2013; Jaklin et al. 2015; Parekh and Klintman 2021), our contribution advances the discussion by specifically investigating the changes that these experiences bring about in the 'practices of eating' (Warde 2016). Through the adoption of a theory-of-practice perspective and focusing on a specific experience established with the explicit goal of promoting sustainable eating among citizens, our aim is to explore the factors that either support or hinder the adoption of more sustainable diets.

Practice theory has already been applied to examine various consumption domains, including food consumption. Many scholars have used this framework to elucidate how changes in practices constitute complex processes that shape everyday behaviors (as exemplified by Sahakian and Wilhite 2014; Jaeger-Erben and Offenberger 2014).

By applying a practice theory perspective, this study digs into two main research questions: (i) what motivates individuals to join Civic Food Networks (CFNs, hereinafter), and what are the consequences of their participation in these organizations for the food that they bring into their households? (ii) How being part of a CFN influences people's everyday food practices, with a specific focus on dietary diversification?

To explore these inquiries, we conduct a comprehensive analysis of "*Naturalmente in Trentino*", a community-supported agriculture (CSA) initiative that was established in 2020 in Trento, a mid-sized city situated in the North-Eastern part of Italy.

Our analysis unveils the intricate challenges associated with the transformation of food practices, which are fraught with obstacles affecting both individuals and institutions.

It is widely acknowledged that food consumption is deeply intertwined with the broader spectrum of household practices (Fuentes and Samsioe 2020). Consequently, any endeavor aimed at altering dietary habits proves to be a formidable undertaking, with far-reaching consequences that can affect other aspects of daily life.

Nonetheless, as we delve into our exploration, the effectiveness of practice theory in revealing the interplay between individual behavior and the larger social structures that underlie these transformative processes helps us avoiding the pitfalls of isolating and stigmatizing individual responsibility. Furthermore, as already posited by Watson and his colleagues in 2020, it provides an enlightening perspective on the collaborative approach to the co-production of public policies for sustainability, offering an alternative vantage point for shaping policy framing.

The article is organized as follows: the next section is devoted to the analysis of the literature. It focuses on the different concepts employed to identify processes of consumer-producer alliances that provide alternatives to the dominant food system, as well as on the relevance of practice theory as a tool for analyzing these organizational arrangements. The article then introduces the context of the analysis, the Province of Trento in Northern Italy, and the methods employed to develop the study. It follows by analyzing empirical data in the light of Warde's categorization of the main components of the practice of eating. We conclude by highlighting some implications regarding members' participation in the CSA analyzed. Finally, future research directions are proposed.

Literature review

In the last two decades, a growing body of literature has documented the upsurge of community-driven processes of consumer-producer cooperation, which partly stand as an alternative to the dominant food system. These organizational arrangements have been defined and conceptualized in different ways, such as alternative food networks (AFNs) (Goodman et al. 2012; Michel-Villarreal et al. 2019), short food-supply chains (SFSCs) (Chiffolleau and Dourian 2020; Renting et al. 2003), civic food networks (Renting et al. 2012; Bos and Owen 2016), local food networks (Guzmán et al. 2013; Tregear 2011), witnessing the growing importance of local communities in generating place-based solutions to the demand for organic, local, and sustainable food.

As frequently asserted, within such endeavors, alternative provisioning serves as a platform for active involvement with the aim of reshaping the significance of food in cultural, environmental, social, and at times, political contexts. This is done in opposition to the commodification of food and unsustainable food production. Scholars have indeed revealed the high

potential of these type of organizations to improve sustainability, especially when considering their social impacts, since they are improving the quality of interactions between producers, consumers and other actors in the political and economic context (Ostrom 2007 cited by Pole and Gray 2013; Brunori et al. 2012; Renting et al. 2012; Grasseni 2014; Cucco and Fonte 2015; Jaklin et al. 2015; Kopczynska 2020). However, their economic and environmental impacts are less homogeneously demonstrated, while their health/nutrition and governance dimensions are still under-explored (Chiffoleau and Dourian 2020).

While many studies have commonly referred to such experiences as “alternative food networks”, often emphasizing their non-mainstream nature, others have pointed out that this term fails to capture the grassroots dynamics fundamental to community engagement in shaping alternative food systems. In these systems, it is asserted that the roles of consumers and civil society are paramount, as emphasized by Renting et al. (2012). Furthermore, the notion of “alternativeness” in alternative food networks has frequently faced criticism due to its static nature. This is because the concept of what constitutes the “mainstream” is in a perpetual state of evolution, and paradoxically, entities initially considered “alternative” might eventually find themselves incorporated into this evolving mainstream. Likewise, the concepts of “local food networks” and “short food supply chains” put their accent predominantly but almost exclusively on a spatial dimension, which we consider relevant since it underlines the re-territorialization and re-localization of food (Sage 2003; Matakana 2016), but not sufficient in order to grasp the complexity of these initiatives.

Additionally, several studies have brought attention to the limited participation of members in ‘alternative’ food networks, encompassing both producers and consumers. This limited involvement is attributed to their predominantly individualistic and utilitarian approach, as emphasized by De Lind in 1999, Pole and Gray 2013, and Oberholtzer in 2004. In this sense, the need of transcending market logic, economic growth and private ownership has been highlighted to identify food networks as “civic” (De Lind 2002, cited by Janklin et al. 2015). This conception acknowledges their overarching objective as surpassing individualistic motives and, instead, advocating for and fortifying collective community actions to establish a more sustainable food system. In this context, CFNs also transcend the idealized notion of community commonly associated with such networks (Pole and Gray 2013).

Conceptual and theoretical approach

In this article, we have chosen to employ the term “civic food networks” to underscore the significance of civil society initiatives within a broader framework of local food system

transformation. It is worth noting that the community-supported agriculture (CSA) here analyzed was originally conceived within the context of a local working group that bears resemblance to a food policy council, a point we will elaborate on further. CFNs sustain a re-socialization of food production, distribution and consumption practices (Matakana 2016) and this concept, even though a shared definition is lacking and boundaries between different interpretations are blurred, stresses the linkage to other initiatives characterized by a transformative potential, such as the solidarity economy, transition towns, de-growth, among others (Renting et al. 2012). CFNs are also interpreted as civil society expressions able to influence governance mechanisms of the state and the market favoring food democracy, food citizenship and food sovereignty (Renting et al. 2012; Jaklin et al. 2015). Even though not all these initiatives are deliberately or potentially transformative, nor necessarily have a prefigurative character, it seems important to consider their capacity to trigger change, starting from considering a “quiet” or “household” sustainability embedded in daily practices of food provisioning and eating. Indeed, these everyday life practices can generate social and environmental impacts that are not always directly connected to market transactions, but that are based, or that somehow favor, self-food provisioning, re-skilling, sharing, bartering, among others (Smith and Jehlicka 2013; Chiffoleau and Dourian 2020; Kopczynska 2020).

In light of this context, numerous studies have recognized practices as the fundamental unit of analysis when investigating the functioning of CFNs (as demonstrated by Fonte 2013; Veen and D’Amico 2019; Zwart and Mathijs 2020; Castelo et al. 2021; Dal Gobbo et al. 2022). Employing a practice theory approach appears useful in order to overcome the interpretation of consumption choices as based exclusively on individual preferences, reconnecting them to broader social structures. In this view, individuals become “carriers” of practices (Reckwitz 2002; Shove et al. 2012), which arise from complex configuration of human actions as inevitably embedded in social structures and resulting from their interaction with evolving infrastructures and institutional framing. Practices, consisting of both doings and sayings, can be simple (dispersed practice) or more complex (integrative practice), and include practical activities and their representations (Schatzki 1996). Consequently, the practice of eating has to be considered as more than merely the physical process of ingestion, since it is a complex activity that is embedded in everyday life (Warde 2016). As a «compound practice», namely a “compound of component practices” not governed by a centralized logic, series of rules or authoritative regulation” (Warde 2016, pp. 10, 96), eating regards: (i) the supplying of food; (ii) cooking; (iii) the organization of meal occasions; (iv) the aesthetic judgment of taste (Warde 2016). As a compound practice, eating is

made up of these different integrative practices, which are weakly coordinated and organized, each one partially following a different logic according to each individual subject who is enacting the practice (Warde 2013). Everyone can thus perform the practice of eating in a different way, since every integrative practice and the way they are connected depend on subjective performance. This is different, for instance, from the practice of driving a car, where practices are much more constrained from the legal and infrastructural points of view (Ibidem).

Changing eating practices becomes then a challenge both at the individual and institutional levels (Warde 2013; Parekh and Klintman 2021). More than thinking about how to provide sustainable food (organic and locally produced), we focus here on the importance of practicing sustainable eating through a constant adaptation and modification of eating practices, that may imply a stronger effort and motivation in food provisioning than more routinized practices, making it difficult for some people to remain engaged (Zwart and Mathijs 2020). Zooming in the internal functioning of a CFN with the lenses of practice theory appears useful in order to shed some light on critical aspects and obstacles to the promotion of sustainable eating. At the same time, it allows to highlight and promote the “practic-ability” of CFNs, re-embedding food production, distribution and consumption from a social and spatial points of view, also with the aim of generating a policy impact (Matacena 2016). In this way, it is possible to point out the complexity of a change towards more sustainable ways of eating, which are not simplistically linked to rational individual choices, but which, on the contrary, depend on the reconnection of producers and consumers to the social and natural environment as well as on dedicated policy interventions.

CFNs appear as suitable instruments for sustainability because they seem capable of promoting sustainable eating, which in turn allows to encourage the adoption of sustainable diets. A sustainable diet is intended as a multidimensional combination of various factors, that do not only focus on nutritional adequacy, but also on: (1) well-being, health, (2) biodiversity, environment, climate, (3) equity, fair trade, (4) eco-friendly, local, seasonal foods, (5) cultural heritage, skills, and (6) food and nutrient needs, food security, and accessibility (Johnston et al. 2014).

Context: the CSA *Naturalmente in Trentino*

The Autonomous Province of Trento is an Italian Alpine Region located in Northeastern Italy, made up of valleys and high mountains with high percentages of steep slopes. These topographical characteristics have always made cultivation activities difficult, and terraces were created to overcome this problem: 20% of Trento’s territory is classified as

agricultural and 50% as forest or pastureland. About 70% of the territory is covered by silvopastoral-agricultural areas, the remaining 30% is categorised as urban. In Trentino, about 7800 farms are involved in the agricultural sector and 40% of them occupy a surface of less than 0.5 hectares. Gross Salable Production (GSP) of the agricultural and forestry sector amounts to 698.4 million Euros, 95% attributable to the agricultural sector and 5% to the forestry sector.

If the agricultural landscape of 200 years ago was characterized by different cultivations, today it is characterized by two main monocultures: apple orchards and vineyards. Fruit growing is the main business, with 33% of the GSP of the agricultural sector, followed by zootechnics with 17%, and viticulture with 15%. Apple production makes up to 82% of the GSP of fruit growing followed by small fruits (as berries) with 11%. Apple orchards extend over 10,798 hectares and involve 5864 farms. The organic sector, although increasing, is still very limited. In 2017, the area cultivated adopting organic methods was 7146.04 ha corresponding to 1.15% of the entire Province’s surface.

The *Naturalmente in Trentino* CSA was founded in 2020 and it is currently made up of 10 producers and 29 households (March 2023) who started to cooperate in the summer following the first wave of the COVID pandemic. The creation of *Naturalmente in Trentino* was supported by “Nutrire Trento” (Feeding Trento), a multi-stakeholder working table established in 2017 by the Municipality and the University of Trento. This case study was chosen since one of the authors was the initiator, together with the Municipality, of the whole initiative and, consequently, she has a diachronic insight on it. The network has three main objectives: (i) promoting sustainable food consumption, (ii) promoting awareness on sustainable food production, (iii) shortening the food chain. It involves farmers, consumers, various civil society groups, researchers and local administrators around the goal of improving the quality of food that supplies the city and providing fair remuneration in the local food chain. Nutrire Trento functions in a manner similar to a food council, underscoring the significance of endorsing and collaboratively developing specific policy measures. These measures are intended not only to support the operations of the CSA, but also to benefit the broader food system and community.

Most of the farmers participating in the CSA are owners of recently founded farms with few employees, often members of their own families, and small dimensions, both in terms of turnover and agricultural area employed. Almost three-quarters of the farms measure less than 8 hectares, which is the average recorded in Trentino by the Rural Development Program. Eight out of the total 11 farms were founded in the last 20 years. CSA is defined as «a community of individuals who pledge support to a farm(s) operation so that the farmland becomes, either legally or spiritually, the community’s farm, with the growers and consumers providing mutual support

and sharing the risks and benefits of food production» (U.S. Department of Agriculture). Typically, CSA develops around a single producer, while in the case analyzed the organizational framework is different, since several producers are involved.

The CSA has taken the legal form of an association and works on a weekly basis. Every Monday, consumers (who decided to define themselves as “eaters”) and producers meet in a greenhouse provided by one of the farmers in order to exchange produce. Orders and economic transactions are handled by a basic digital platform, which only serves to make it easier to display available products and place orders. Every producer takes care of her orders, one producer is responsible for the platform, which also serves several Solidarity Purchase Groups in the region. Eaters can order single products or purchase weekly boxes containing a variety of products. In addition, the community life of the CSA is based on social dinners, farm visits, meetings with authors and scholars from the food industry and meetings of the board and members' assemblies, even though these activities are not held on a regular basis, and contacts among eaters and between eaters and producers are quite sporadic. Voluntary work is employed in the form of organizing events and managing orders, but in the latter case this is part of producers' daily job, while some producers are more committed than others to the collective endeavor (especially the president of the association). On the side of eaters, there is voluntary work in participating in the board of the organization and in participating in specific initiatives where the CSA is promoted. Differently from “typical” CSA, where risk sharing and collective labor are essential parts of the organization (Endres and Armstrong, 2014), in this case the economic sustainability of the association is not an issue, since the organizational setting is very basic and counts on basic voluntary work, a space freely provided by one of the producers, and the symbolic association fee that covers the basic running costs. In this respect, *Naturalmente in Trentino* operates in a manner similar to a Solidarity Purchase Group (as discussed in studies by Fonte 2013, and Forno et al. 2015). The primary focus is on gaining control over the food consumed by citizens, with the aim of accessing ethically and ecologically produced food (as emphasized in the work of Brunori et al. 2012) by fostering new partnerships between producers and consumers (as highlighted by Grasseni 2014). It is worth noting that, at least for the time being, there is no involvement of community labor in the fields, and the sharing of risks is not part of this arrangement.

Methodology

This study is based on a multi-method qualitative approach, including participant observation in meetings and events promoted by the CSA, in-depth interviews with almost all

members of the CSA (27 out of 29), and one focus groups with seven members of the CSA (Table 1). Interviews were carried out between November 2021 and January 2022. They were tape recorded and fully transcribed, while the focus group (held in May 2022) was video and tape recorded and fully transcribed. Interviews content mainly focused on food provisioning and eating habits, also including a comparison between food bought at the CSA and from other provisioning sources, as well as on cooking, food preparation and food storage. Moreover, there were specific questions directed to understand what motivated the participation in the CSA, and what were the preferences in terms of products, modality of provisioning, and usage of the online platform for placing orders.

The focus group had a duration of 2 h and 30 min and focused, through various guided activities and conversations, on understanding how and why certain types of food enter the households, what a typical food basket contains, what good food means to participants, what are the most important considerations when shopping for food. A final session

Table 1 People interviewed

	Code	Gender	Age	Profession
1	AZ	M	49	Business development (consultant)
2	AT*	M	44	Enologist
3	AP	F	27	Architect, PhD student
4	CB	F	45	Marketing manager
5	DC	F	54	Public servant
6	ES*	F	45	Employee
7	FL	M	45	Public servant
8	FP	M	40	Entrepreneur
9	FC	F	54	Public servant
10	GC*	F	36	Employee
11	GO	M	79	Pensioner
12	GN	M	57	Counselor
13	GP	F	45	Teacher
14	GL	F	52	Unemployed
15	LF	F	49	Public servant
16	LN	F	35	Teacher
17	LS	F	N/A	Public servant
18	LST	F	44	Employee
19	MS*	F	24	Student
20	NDA	F	46	Computer technician
21	PF	F	51	Public servant
22	RF*	M	72	Pensioner
23	SB	F	37	Photographer
24	SR	F	53	Public servant
25	SF*	F	36	University professor
26	SM	F	36	Architect, PhD student
27	SN*	M	28	Worker

*they also participated in the focus group

was devoted to mapping the functional foodscape, indicating on a city map all relevant food provisioning modes, also exploring opinions about the local food system borders as well as the extent to which lack of local diversity (food retail or production) is a barrier towards more sustainable diets.

Participant observation was employed on site where eaters collect their orders, at several meetings and events where the CSA was presented, with the aim of getting a general insight of the context and relations among members.

As illustrated in Fig. 1, the analysis was based on coding interviews and focus groups content according to recurrent themes that were grouped in second order themes and then turned into aggregate dimensions, following the Gioia methodology (Gioia et al. 2013). Each aggregate dimension corresponded to one of the Warde's categories of practice theory that will be described in the following section.

Analysis

As mentioned, the main focus of this study was on understanding the motivations for the participation in the CSA and how this participation influences practices and the type of food that enters the household, analyzing how participants in the CSA enact and perform their eating practices.

The analysis draws on Warde's (2005) categorization of the three key components of practices: understandings, procedures and engagements. Following Schatzki (1996), Warde employs three labels in order to identify the way in which practices are performed: understandings, i.e., shared

meanings and values that determine certain practices; procedures, i.e., the explicit rules and instructions that drive practices; and engagements, i.e., the “teleoaffective” structures that motivate certain practices and that involves emotions, beliefs, ends and moods.

Understandings

The understandings component is useful in order to address the question whether CSA members share a common conception of what the desirable characteristics of food are: this is a relevant aspect in order to investigate collective ways of doing and saying, namely collectively shared meanings and values that are constantly reproduced while practiced (Warde 2005).

When examining data related to this component, it becomes evident that people participating in the CSA often hold distinct perceptions of what desirable food characteristics entail. According to CSA members, food encompasses a range of aspects that can vary from person to person. In particular, by grouping primary concepts, we have identified three main dimensions:

i) De-commodification of food

The most important aspect, according to eaters, is that food is thought as a relational good, not as a commodity, and as something that has to be “local”. Moreover, the fact that producers are committed to sustainability practices is highlighted and valued, as one interviewee highlights:

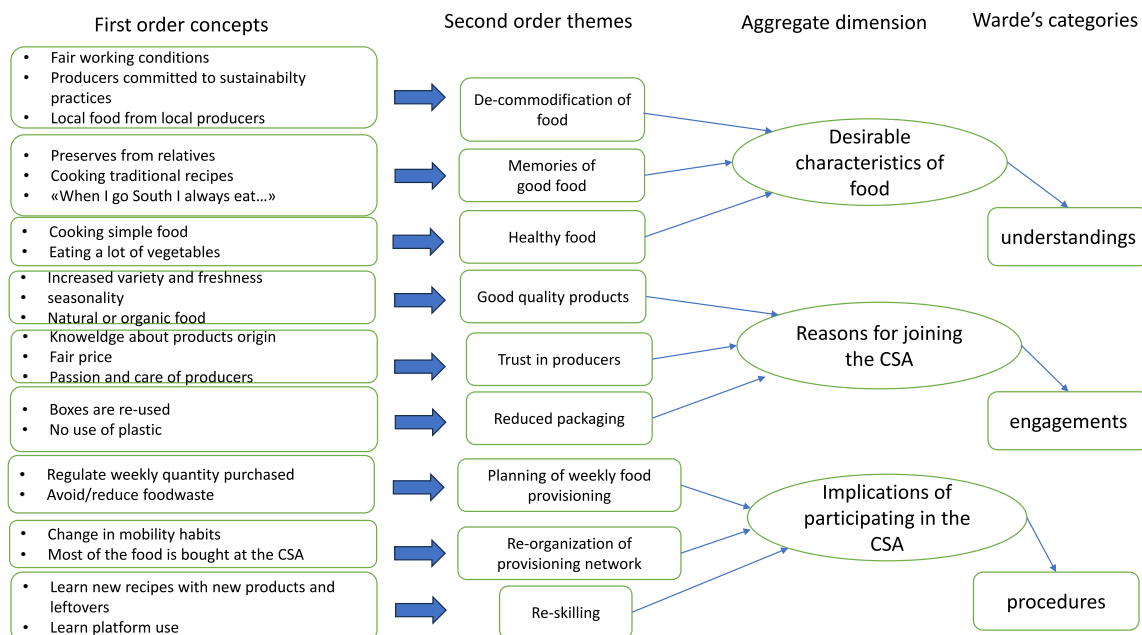


Fig. 1 Data coding

“Quality, eco-sustainability, something that is good for the environment, many other aspects that when I talk to many people they tell me ‘ok, but what do you think you can do when there are multinational corporations that are more powerful?’ And so, what do I say? I just try! And, also when I go to the supermarket, I try to choose local products” (ES, female, interview)

In addition, there is consciousness about the importance of short supply chains, and having access to local food is reputed as more important than getting organic food, as one eater stresses:

“Local food, even though not necessarily organic, is definitely better than a produce you buy in the supermarket, even if it’s organic you don’t know exactly where it comes from, how it was transported, in which conditions it was produced...so I prefer a “natural” product that is local, directly bought from a producer, where the money goes directly to the producer” (AZ, male, interview)

Moreover, fair working conditions for people working in agriculture are deemed as crucial, as some interviewees stress:

“I think that prices are very good, and I imagine that higher prices are due to the fact that work is better rewarded than what is done in the traditional market. So, I agree with that and I am also happy about that” (MS, female, interview)

“For example, at the LIDL. The issue is that when you analyze the product it is impossible that they can sell it at that price adhering with labor standards. How could a product from, let’s say, Bangladesh, that has travelled to arrive here be so cheap? It means that people work for one euro a day. So, I refuse to buy it”. (RF, male, focus group)

The idea of sustainability is related to environmental and health concerns, but also to labour rights:

“If we talk about vegetables, sustainability comes from how that vegetable was produced: soil exploitation, emissions, pest management, and beyond this environmental sustainability, how do they pay people, what type of contracts they make them” (FP, male, interview)

Waste reduction is not entirely practiced by all eaters, but still is deemed as something crucial, and efforts are made in this direction, as one participant tells:

“I still have a very negative impact, because unfortunately this lifestyle, which I’m still not able to change or balance, leads me to generate waste. My big issue

is waste, which is improving, but unfortunately is still there”. (SF, female, interview)

ii) Healthy food

Health concerns are also very present, as one eater exemplify:

“I’ve always talked about a sustainable and healthy meal. Healthy is very important, since I believe that the first part of the resistance to external factors, like diseases, starts from how you eat.” (AZ, male, interview)

Moreover, almost all interviewees stress the fact that they eat a lot of vegetables, being them present in every meal they have, and that they prefer to cook traditional food, not too elaborated and employing very simple recipes, as two interviewees stress:

“The food we prepare are not very seasoned and this allowed me to solve many physical problems, because my body has appreciated this type of diet”. (RF, male, interview)

“To go back to a simple cuisine, with products that are not manipulated by the industry. Without being an extremist, yet preferring what you can cook with what you find in nature and that is not transformed by the industry”. (DC, female, interview)

Healthy food is also related to self-production, as two eaters stress:

“We make bread and pizza at home. At breakfast we eat our bread and home-made jam, so we are sure that there are no preservatives”. (RF, male, interview)

“We have a garden at home and we grow lettuce, tomatoes, not many things, but I like the idea of producing something and knowing how it is produced” (SN, male, Interview)

iii) Memories of good-food

In some cases, eaters highlight their origins from different Italian regions and the memories of what they used to eat there (Dal Gobbo et al. 2022), as one interviewee stresses:

“The pictures relate to the pantry...below are the preserves that my mom and my aunt make, because my parents live in Abruzzo, so when they come to see us they bring me all the things they make. There are also some olives that my mom prepares, and some tomato preserves from an organic producer from Abruzzo. They are all gifts, I didn’t buy any of this stuff here, but I use it”. (GC, female, focus group)

“I would start here (she shows the picture) with arrosticini (lamb skewers), I don't eat a lot of meat, however arrosticini for an Abruzzese is inevitable. So, when I go down (South of Italy) there is always an ‘arrosticini moment’” (GC, female, focus group)

However, some of them are open to recipes from other countries, which are prepared at home or eaten in specialized restaurants (even though in Trento there are not many choices, some complain).

Engagements

The engagements component helps understanding what supported eaters' decision of getting engaged in the CSA.

i) Good quality products

A crucial dimension related to the engagements component, is that the involvement in the CSA allows for an increase in products variety, quality, and freshness, also related to the fact of consuming seasonal food. As one participant underlines:

“I am very happy to always see vegetables that are different from the four varieties we were used to. It's nice to vary and to see two boxes that are really full of many things, and sometimes there are very special things.” (MS, female, focus group)

Obviously, seasonality also implies that in winter there are very few products available.

ii) Trust in producers

Eaters stress that the CSA enhances direct contacts with producers, increasing interpersonal trust:

“The first thing I think about is that when I buy at the CSA I know where products come from and I know producers, while at the supermarket I have no idea about the supply chain.” (GC, female, interview)

“The main difference is quality, knowing where the produce comes from, not only physically, but knowing stories, how producers work, knowing that there are values and principles behind that production (in their job, in the care they put in it, in their passion), and in the idea of networking and community” (SF, female, interview)

“I love the fact of having a project in common with farmers” (FL, male, interview)

Eaters give value to the passion and care of farmers in their daily work, even though there are also some critical considerations in this respect, and in some cases, there is a certain lack of trust towards producers, who seem to take

advantage of the situation in order to place scarce quality produce at the same price as regular produce. Some eaters complain about the quality of certain products found at the CSA, that they would not buy if they saw them before, and that do not justify the price they have. Some say they occasionally had to throw away part of the produce they bought. Some eaters express the desire of having some advantage for being members, for instance in terms of discounts:

“I make a trivial example: there is this bread, that of (he mentions the name of the producer). What happens? That if you want, you can buy it at the local bakery. You check the price and you say: why does it cost 10€ per kilo at the CSA and 8,90€ at the bakery? I know it's a silly thing, but you think...I am part of the CSA, give me an advantage, why don't you?” (FP, male, interview)

Regarding price considerations, in general eaters perceive prices as fair, even though some say that prices are very high on certain products and that they cannot afford to buy, for instance, flour for 5€ per kilo (interview GP), while some highlight the fact that there is a good value for money, as one interviewee stresses:

“I realize that regarding price it is a little more expensive, but it's justified by the fact that you perceive it while eating, quality is much better and products are more tasteful. Maybe at the beginning it's a little hard, but then you realize that it's worth it.” (SN, male, interview)

The engagement component also explains that engaging in the CSA is a way to get access to local food, one of the desired characteristics of food that the understandings component highlighted. Getting access to local food is deemed more relevant than having access to organic food, since the latter is a blurring concept that can be applied to types of food produced in very many different ways. Indeed, it is important to stress that in the focus group there was agreement about the fact that local food is not only the food produced in the region, but that it also depends on the type of product concerned. There are obviously products that cannot grow in the local area, due to climate and soil characteristics. In this sense, eaters mention the fact that they use to buy products, such as for instance olive oil or oranges, directly from producers they trust when traveling to other regions of Italy. The concept of local food is then not a strict one, only related to kilometric distance, but it depends on other more flexible factors related to the characteristics of the territory. As one interviewee explains:

“What I am looking for (in the CSA) is local production and then, consequently, the origin. I am interested in knowing where a product comes from because I am

interested in reducing the distance between production and consumption: that's proximity." (SF, female, focus group)

iii) Reduced packaging

Another element related to engagements is provided by the fact that packaging is minimal, since products are provided in boxes that are constantly re-used, reducing plastic usage, an aspect that is underlined as very relevant by many of the interviewees.

"Moreover, they don't have packaging because they bring you products in a box, and this is also great!" (MS, female, interview)

"Even though I am not an environmental activist, when I get home, put the things in the pantry (after buying at the CSA) and realizing that I don't have a lot of plastic to throw away...that's really impressive. If you ask me why (I joined the CSA), I say so: less plastic packaging and local food". (GC, female, interview)

Procedures

Procedures help understanding what the participation in the CSA enables for its members, in terms of changing different habits and practices related to food provision and consumption.

i) Planning of weekly food provisioning

The first impact of the CSA is on an increased planning in food consumption, since members are more eager to plan what to buy and when, given the weekly character of the CSA delivery. Moreover, they tend to limit the quantity the buy in order to avoid foodwaste, as one participant remarks:

"I never buy too many things (at the CSA) because I always consume everything and if I don't eat everything that week, then I keep what I bought for the following week and on that week, I buy a little less. For the quantity of food, I have never thrown away anything so far". (DC, female, interview)

Another eater highlights how being member of CSA has reduced food waste in his household:

"There is a double satisfaction that derives from having found a solution to two elements: one is that of always having something at home, so you don't get home and there's nothing to eat; the other one is to reduce food waste, because you don't accumulate too many things that you're not able to manage, and you have the time to plan and think about (what to buy)". (AT, male, interview)

However, some interviewees highlight the difficulties related to planning and managing provision through the CSA:

"I often eat out due to my job, and this is one of the reasons why I can't manage the CSA, if I buy half a kilo of carrots, they last for two months...Since I live alone and I am in a quite unstable period, I had several difficulties in participating in the CSA, because I can't really plan my provisioning whatsoever". (AP, female, interview)

ii) Re-organization of provisioning network

The CSA also favors eaters' re-organization of the personal provisioning network, becoming in most of the cases the main food provisioning source. Members thus reduce the number of other provisioning sources, as emerged from an activity dedicated to mapping their foodscape during the focus group, and as two participants underline:

"Since I have joined the CSA, this is where I buy most of our food. (...) These (other) places are supplementary, since I only buy things that I cannot find at the CSA". (AT, male, focus group)

"We only dine in, on weekends we are never at home, and so with the CSA I have drastically reduced buying in other places". (GC, female, focus group)

The participation in the CSA helps some eaters in reconciling family life with the search for local food, since some of them highlight that it is more convenient going to the CSA on Mondays to pick up their food, than going to the farmers' market on Saturdays, and this leaves space for more pleasant familiar activities on the weekend. However, some complain about the CSA venue, not very convenient for people who live and work in the city center and difficult to be reached by bicycle or on foot, especially in the winter season. Picking up products at the CSA also implies a re-organization of mobility habits among family members. In this respect, one eater highlights the difficulties she has in collecting orders at the CSA and the fact that the way it is organized does not favor sustainable mobility:

"We should organize differently, but sometimes it is difficult because we have meetings until late in the evening and we don't have a fixed working schedule, so for us 17.30-19.30 (the time when eaters can collect the produce they ordered) is working time. And then also the place is not very convenient, because if it was in the city center we could go to pick up orders on foot, while in this way we always have to go by car, and this is a little contradictory: I never use car, while to go there I have no other options, it seems to me an unsustainable situation". (SF, female, interview)

iii) re-skilling

Re-skilling is another effect at least partially due to the participation in the CSA. This is true, for instance, about learning and getting used to the online platform, instead of going to the supermarket or farmers' market, as one participant (in his 70 s), underlines:

"This is one of the reasons why I have to get used, and my wife as well, not to go to the farmers' markets, but to go on the internet and use Agoragas (the online platform). These also become habits if you learn how to use them and if you get used to them". (RF, male, interview)

Re-skilling becomes evident also in the descriptions of how participants are able to take advantage of what they ordered, sometimes in a too large amount. The online platform changes the relation they have with quantities, since eaters do not physically see what they are buying, they just order by kilos or a mixed vegetable box, not exactly realizing what amount of produce they will receive, consequently improving planning, as already mentioned:

"With the CSA you have time to think about it because, if you get to the last minute you have to sit down, take your time to check the available orders, think about what to buy, and you also see how much money you are spending (this also helps in deciding), and you manage to ask yourself some questions (like for instance do I need it?)" (AT, male, interview)

Eaters also stress the fact that they have learnt how to cook seasonal products that were previously unknown, experimenting with new recipes and increasing the re-utilization of food leftovers. The fact that the CSA allowed them to understand which are the seasonal products, is described by one participant as follows:

"Sometimes I'm wrong with quantities, but then I'm able to cook with leftovers, so I just invent something, and we never throw away food. Then, obviously, at the supermarket I can find whatever I want, also out of season, like zucchini in winter or tropical fruit. It is a paradigm change, so you get used to know which are the seasonal products in this territory". (GC, female, interview)

Discussion

The analysis has highlighted how eaters' different perceptions of what desirable characteristics of food are can be related to the concept of "good food" (Sage 2003). This

implies considering different properties of food, which are related both to "natural" and "cultural" characteristics of products. As emerged from the analysis and following Sage (2003), it is possible to stress categories of good food related to: (i) embodied properties ("quality", taste, healthiness, appearance); (ii) ecologically embedded characteristics (waste and packaging reduction, naturalness, localness); (iii) socially embedded features (short supply chain, relations with producers). Related to the third aspect, as highlighted by other studies (e.g., Dal Gobbo et al. 2022), an important aspect of good food is also related to 'memories' of conviviality and tasteful food, a characteristic that is especially present among people whose origins are from other regions of Italy and find in this way a connection to their memories.

It is possible to interpret the participation and the motivation of engaging in the CSA as a reaction to processes of globalization, commodification and aestheticization of food (Warde 2005). This seems to be confirmed by the fact that, as described above, participating in the CSA implies an increased politicization of food, even though at the same time the CSA attracts people who somehow had this vision before joining the CSA and who were searching for alternative, more sustainable food provisioning channels. As highlighted, the main desired characteristic of food that enters the household is that of locally produced food with sustainable methods in terms of biodiversity, respect for seasonality, organic production, fair working conditions, reduced packaging, and the possibility to establish direct relations with producers.

Furthermore, this study permits to highlight how being part of a CFN, a CSA in this specific case, allows for the stabilization of embodied habits, temporal routines and shared norms within social networks. The main result of participating in the CSA is that it increases mindful eating, reducing purchases in large organized distribution, increasing food consumption planning, and re-organizing the provisioning network, where the CSA becomes the main source of weekly food provision. Eaters, who have different and multidimensional conceptions of good food, find in the CSA an infrastructure that permits to embody these conceptions. In this sense, CFNs can be seen as evolving infrastructures (Parekh and Klintman 2021) that support the practice of sustainable eating, that is to say the incorporation in practices of the dimensions that constitute sustainable diets (Johnston et al. 2014). Indeed, the CSA analyzed is constantly transforming and adapting to the needs of eaters and producers. This has recently happened through opening the doors to new producers, constantly keeping members in touch through a new discussion group (via WhatsApp), organizing visits to producers and meetings to discuss the main issues at stake.

Obviously, this process is not exempt from contradictions, and the main limitation to emphasize is that eaters belong to the same socioeconomic profile: white middle-class couples

or families, with high levels of education and relatively stable professional lives, confirming what emerged from several studies (e.g., Goodman 2004; Veen and D'Amico 2019; Zwart and Mathijis 2020). One of the main challenges is indeed to make CFNs accessible to less privileged sectors of society, who cannot afford the cost and the type of re-organization of their daily lives and routines required in order to access and participate in the CSA.

Conclusion

This study has highlighted that changing eating practices implies several challenges at the individual and institutional levels. At the individual level, the challenge consists of showing a disposition to change practices in food provisioning as well as in cooking habits, for instance devoting more time to the search for “good food” or learning how to cook seasonal products and adapt to their seasonality through a process of re-skilling. The analysis shows that these practices are not always easily achieved, and several hurdles still exist, as witnessed by the fact that nearly half of the members interviewed are at present (May 2023) not members anymore, confirming that daily practices are hard to be adapted to the reorganization that alternative provisioning implies, being sometimes in conflict with daily life (Zwart and Mathijis 2020). As often emphasized, food consumption exists in a nexus of household practices (Fuentes and Samsoe 2020). Changing how one shops for food connects, in fact, with a series of food (cooking, eating, storing food) and non-food (working, picking up kids, exercising) practices. Change is, therefore, both difficult and can have unforeseen (ripple) effects on other habits. Therefore, while the motivation to be more sustainable can lead consumers to try alternative food provisioning networks, not all of them are willing or sufficiently motivated to do the extra ‘consumer work’ required, namely a greater effort in terms of provisioning planning, and greater time consumption in order to collect food and learn how to prepare and cook new products, as illustrated above (see also Zwart and Mathijis 2020).

At the institutional level, as already highlighted, there is the need to make CFNs accessible also to people whose economic and knowledge resources are limited. As a consequence, the role of food policies appears crucial, and it should act on understandings, engagements and procedures in view of promoting sustainable eating. Put differently, thinking about promoting sustainable food, intended as the production of local organic food, is not sufficient in order to support the sustainability of the food system. On the contrary, a “multifunctional vision of food” is needed, able to drive networking between food systems (Matacena

2016). Consequently, the complexity of the food system, that includes food-related socio-economic issues, requires supporting policies for sustainable eating, that is to say dedicated support policies for a plurality of components. Such components are those that emerged from the analysis and include health, biodiversity and climate, equity and fair trade, local seasonal food, cultural heritage and re-skilling, food security and accessibility (Johnston et al. 2014). The transformative potential that CFNs typically show, in the case analyzed seems still embryonic, due to the limited involvement of eaters and to some difficulties in coordinating collective activities. However, there is a potential for the CSA to operate as a CFN: there are surely attempts of creating a community that work together (De Lind 2002), though social events, visits to the farms, initiatives for promoting the CSA directed to the larger public, education projects dedicated to different publics in which consumers and producers participate, generating new forms of food citizenship (Renting et al. 2012), but they need to be reinforced. It is also true that CFNs can be interpreted as places for enacting strategies of quiet sustainability connected to local food provisioning, re-skilling, reduced food waste (Smith and Jehlicka 2013).

Moreover, the mere existence of the CSA is to be interpreted as the result of a process of creation of relationship with different actors in the local institutional space (political-economic context, Renting et al. 2012), since it derives from a municipal table directed to the co-creation of public policies. More in general, these practices have certainly had a direct or indirect capacity of influencing local policies (Moragues et al. 2013; Cretella 2016; Matacena 2016), as witnessed by the diffusion of urban food strategies observed during the last decade (like the table *Nutrire Trento*, in the case here analyzed). Moreover, the study confirms that CFNs somehow invert the origin of food-system innovation, since from the rural/production side the accent is put on the urban/consumption character of these initiatives (Renting et al. 2012).

Further research is needed in order to explore the internal dynamics of CFNs in different contexts by applying practice theory, in order to highlight strengths and limitations of these organizational arrangements for food sustainability and their transformative potential, that include their capacity to expand and to have an influence on local food policies. At a different level, given the role that municipalities can play in scaling these processes, we envision the potential for further research also in exploring the contribution of CFNs in emerging urban food strategies (Giovannini and Forno 2023).

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